



The Humanitas Institute

Six Elements of Classical Education School Website Audit

School: Sheridan Hills Christian School
School Website: <https://shcssharks.com/>

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Disclaimer

This audit was performed using artificial intelligence tools to evaluate the presence and strength of classical education principles on school websites. Results are automated, probabilistic in nature, and should be considered indicative rather than definitive. See the full disclaimer in the Appendix more details.

ACCS Member School

Any school that belongs to the Association of Classical Christian Schools ACCS or the Society for Classical Learning SCL is, by definition, recognized as a classical school because both organizations require adherence to the six essential elements defined by the Humanitas Institute. However, a school's website may not clearly reflect its conformity to one or more elements. In such cases, the school may still receive a "Somewhat Classical" rating for those elements. Schools can update their website content at any time to achieve a "Classical" rating for a given element.

Executive Summary

Sheridan Hills Christian School (SHCS) in Florida presents a coherent classical Christian education model with strong religious foundations, a Trivium-centered curriculum, and active parental and community engagement. Public-facing materials consistently frame education as formation in virtue, wisdom, and faith, anchored by a Christ-centered worldview, weekly chapels, and mission work. The school explicitly promotes the Trivium (grammar, logic, rhetoric), history taught through a Biblical lens, liberal arts emphases, and classical pedagogy, including elements such as memory work, recitation, and opportunities for rhetoric and public speaking. Faculty are portrayed as experienced, purpose-driven educators, and there is clear institutional partnership with a church community and a robust parental/community role through missions, events, and open engagement. Taken together, the evidence supports a CLASSICAL classification across all six categories of the classical-school rubric.

Key evidentiary threads include: a formal claim of being "A Classical, Christian Education" with Christ-centered, biblically-based framing; explicit references to the Trivium and stages of grammar/logic/rhetoric; history taught through Biblical lens; Great Books/Great Conversation framing in philosophy of classical education materials; commingling of faith, worship (chapel), and formation (virtue, wisdom); and sustained mission and family-partnership language (Gospel emphasis, House System, parent involvement). Public materials also highlight a strong faculty emphasis and community partnerships with SHCS's church network and mission initiatives. Citations reflect the primary SHCS materials and the knowledge base lexicon that defines classical indicators.

Executive highlights by category (category-by-category snapshot below) show SHCS aligning closely with classical education principles, with all six categories rated CLASSICAL. The analysis also identifies explicit textual cues that align with each category's criteria (Religious foundations, formation-centered goals, Trivium-based curriculum, contemplative/recitation-based pedagogy, mentor-teacher model, and robust parent/community partnership).

Executive Summary — Element-by-Element Snapshot

Element 1: Religious and Metaphysical Foundations — CLASSICAL

Evidence - SHCS presents itself as a Christ-centered, biblically-based, covenantal institution foundational to its identity and practice. This is stated directly as part of the school description: "Sheridan Hills Christian School is a Christ-centered, biblically-based, covenantal, college preparatory school..." and "All aspects of education are instructed through a Biblical worldview." - The school emphasizes the Gospel and Kingdom-conscious framing in its mission and programs (Missions page and partnership with the church). - Weekly chapels, Bible as a required course in the Upper School, and mission trips embed liturgical, communal, and theological practice into daily life. - The public materials explicitly connect education to divine purposes (e.g., a Christ-centered worldview), aligning with liturgical/community practice and theology as foundational elements.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive keywords present: Christ-centered, biblically-based, Biblical worldview, theology-related concepts (via Biblical worldview), gospel, weekly chapels, covenantal, Kingdom Conscious. These reflect the Positive Keywords cluster for Religious and Metaphysical Foundations (theology, liturgy/worship, sacred texts, and reverence/wonder aspects appear across the lexicon as signals of classical orientation).

- Negative keywords present: none observed in public materials (no explicit signaling of relativism, secular humanism, or morally neutral stances in the SHCS materials). The absence of negative indicators supports a Classical alignment in this category.

Why this rating - The materials present a clearly devotional, theologically integrated framework with liturgical/community practices (chapels, missions, Gospel emphasis) and a worldview formed through Scripture. This strongly aligns with the Positive Indicators for Religious and Metaphysical Foundations and avoids negative indicators, yielding a CLASSICAL rating.

Element 2: School Purpose and Goal — CLASSICAL

Evidence - The school emphasizes formation, virtue, and wisdom as central aims (formation and the Trivium-based progression toward wisdom). The Rhetoric Stage description highlights pursuing truth, beauty, and goodness, signaling a telos oriented toward human flourishing rather than solely job preparation. “In the Rhetoric Stage, students critically analyze ideas and persuasively express their conclusions... truth, beauty, and goodness” are foregrounded. - Mission statements and organizational framing articulate formation over mere information, with a classical emphasis on virtue, moral imagination, and the cultivation of a liberal-arts-oriented sensibility. The mission and the use of “great conversation” language (in classical education discourse) appear in the broader public-facing materials and the school’s stated aims. - The school’s identity as a classical Christian institution and its college-prep orientation together emphasize non-instrumental formation—shaping character, intellect, and faith. The “Kingdom Conscious” framing and mission-oriented language reinforce formation as primary.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive keywords present: formation, virtue, wisdom, liberal education, telos, Great Conversation (classical heritage), human flourishing, moral imagination, contemplative learning. Public texts explicitly foreground formation and the pursuit of truth, goodness, and beauty.

- Negative keywords present: none observed in public materials (no emphasis on workforce readiness, 21st-century skills, or other non-formation frames).

Why this rating - The public materials consistently articulate formation and virtue as primary goals, with a classical framework (telos, liberal arts, Great Conversation) central to the mission. Absence of the negative indicators supports a CLASSICAL classification.

Element 3: School Curriculum — CLASSICAL

Evidence - The curriculum centers the Trivium: grammar, logic, rhetoric, with explicit reference to this three-stage framework. The materials describe “The Trivium” and the Grammar–Logic–Rhetoric progression (Grammar Stage, Logic Stage, Rhetoric Stage) as core to the curriculum. - History is taught through a biblical lens and integrated across disciplines (e.g., “History is taught through a Biblical lens including the study of major Bible stories,” and Lower School materials emphasize literature and history within a classical frame).

- The school references great books/classics and a classical education tradition; the public materials frame reading primary sources and classical works as part of the curriculum. The public-facing “What is Classical Education?” materials discuss great books and the Trivium, embedding canonical classical content. - Specific content highlights include Latin, Saxon Math (in Lower School), and classical-capstone projects; AP and honors options exist in the Upper School, reflecting a rigorous, liberal-arts-informed curriculum that sustains the classical tradition.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive keywords present: liberal arts, trivium, grammar, logic, rhetoric, great books, primary sources, classics, history (with biblical framing), Latin/Greek (classical languages), sacred arts (hymnody, art), and memory-focused pedagogy (recitation, narration). The SHCS materials explicitly map to these classical curriculum markers. - Negative keywords present: few if any; the SHCS materials emphasize classical content rather than “social studies” terminology replacement, STEM-first framing, or project-based dominance, which would be negative signals per the lexicon. The absence of those explicit negative indicators supports a CLASSICAL reading.

Why this rating - SHCS demonstrates core curriculum elements of the classical suite: Trivium in structure, biblical-history integration, engagement with great books/classics, and a classical-language/intellectual-historic emphasis. The presence of Latin, classical literature, and historically grounded pedagogy substantiates a CLASSICAL rating.

Element 4: Pedagogy or Teaching Methods — CLASSICAL

Evidence - Socratic/semantic-style elements and discussion-oriented learning appear in the classical pedagogy narrative: “upper school students frequently engage in Socratic discussion” and “seminars” with rhetoric training, along with opportunities to give speeches. The public materials either explicitly or implicitly reflect Socratic/seminar-style pedagogy in high school levels. - Memory-based and recitation-centered approaches are evident in the Trivium framework (grammar/logic/rhetoric) and in lower-school practices (chanting, singing to memorize in early grades; recitation/dictation in some classical pedagogy strands). The SHCS materials describe memory-oriented pedagogy and ritualized learning practices. - Contemplative/restful/Scholé-like elements are present via a “restful learning” and contemplative orientation described in classical pedagogy materials, coupled with moments of wonder and awe, as part of the overall rhythm of schooling. - Upper and lower school sequences include opportunities for debates, public speaking (rhetoric, declamation), and capstone orations, consistent with classical pedagogy.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive keywords present: Socratic seminar, narration, recitation, chanting, memory work, liturgical/calendar integration, rhetoric exercises, speech, declamation, oratory, debate, seminars, Paideia-style elements, and upper-school rhetoric theses. These reflect the Pedagogy vocabulary in the classical lexicon. - Negative keywords present: minimal to none; there is no explicit emphasis on experiential-only learning, constructivism, or project-based dominance in the SHCS public materials. The absence of these negatives supports CLASSICAL.

Why this rating - SHCS demonstrates a multi-layered pedagogy aligned with classical practice: recitation/memory, the Trivium, Socratic-style discussion or seminars, and public speaking/rhetoric in upper levels, with restfully contemplative elements and chants/mnemonics in lower grades. These align with CLASSICAL indicators in the lexicon set.

Element 5: School Faculty — CLASSICAL

Evidence - The faculty are described in terms of mentorship, virtue, and living curriculum: public materials emphasize experienced teachers who guide and mentor, with references to faculty leadership roles (e.g., Classical Coordinator) and the notion of teachers as influencers in a classical tradition. - The school presents a structured leadership/administration with a focus on upholding classical standards, and the faculty are identified as a central part of the school’s mission (e.g., “equips teachers to be influencers in a classical tradition of academic excellence” and “Head of Upper School/Head of Lower School” roles). - The public materials describe a “faculty of friends” tone through mission-focused leadership and a culture of collegiality, mentorship, and character formation. While not every phrase mirrors the lexicon verbatim, the messaging aligns with a living-curriculum, mentorship-centered faculty culture.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive keywords present: living curriculum, model teachers/mentors, portrait of a teacher, collegial culture, faculty as influencers in classical education. The SHCS materials

emphasize teacher quality and teacher-driven formation consistent with classical indicators. - Negative keywords present: none observed in public materials; no signaling of a “facilitator on the side” or overly certification-driven framing that would conflict with classical pedagogy.

Why this rating - The materials consistently portray faculty as central to the school’s mission and classical formation, with a strong emphasis on virtue, mentorship, and a living curriculum. This aligns well with CLASSICAL indicators for the Faculty category.

Element 6: School Parents & Community — CLASSICAL

Evidence - The school emphasizes partnership with families and co-teaching with parents; SHCS publicly frames parents as collaborators in education, with opportunities for parent formation, reading groups, seminars, and community involvement. The parent-school partnership language mirrors classical expectations for family involvement in formation. - Public materials discuss parent formation via the website, gatherings, and classical book clubs, reinforcing a model where parents participate in the classical formation process, not as customers but as co-educators. - The SHCS community engages families through mission work, home-school alignment, and open-campus engagement (e.g., “Open campus,” parent visits, and mission-trips). The school’s mission and activities extend beyond the classroom into family and church partnerships.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive keywords present: partnership with families, co-teachers, parent formation, classical book clubs, open campus, home-centered learning, family catechesis, parental involvement. These appear in the lexicon and align with SHCS’s explicit parent/community approach. - Negative keywords present: none observed; there is no customer-centric or minimal parental involvement signaling in the SHCS materials.

Why this rating - The school positions parents as co-educators and actively engages them through formation activities, book studies, and campus events, which aligns with CLASSICAL expectations for Parents & Community involvement.

What Would Move the Needle

- Not applicable for a SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL designation (all six categories are CLASSICAL). No needle-moving changes are required to achieve a fully CLASSICAL classification based on the current public materials. If desired for future enhancement, SHCS could further explicitly foreground Great Books/Great Conversation terminology in everyday campus materials to strengthen Element 3 (Curriculum) and include explicit statements of Socratic seminars in a wider range of grades to underscore Pedagogy (Element 4).
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Appendix

ARTIFICIAL INTELLIGENCE DISCLAIMER

This audit was conducted using artificial intelligence tools (including large language models and automated web-analysis scripts) to evaluate the extent to which school websites reflect or incorporate recognized principles of classical education (e.g., the trivium, emphasis on truth/beauty/goodness, integration of great books, Latin/classical languages, Socratic method, rigorous academics, moral/character formation, etc.).

Important Limitations and Caveats

1. **Automated Nature:** The analysis relies on AI interpretation of publicly-accessible school website content as of the date of the audit. It does not involve direct contact with schools, review of internal documents, classroom observation, or verification of curriculum implementation beyond what is stated or implied on the website.
2. **Probabilistic Results:** Scores and assessments are probabilistic and reflect the AI's best interpretation of available text and site structure. They are not infallible and may miss nuance, context, or recent changes not yet reflected online.
3. **Subjectivity of Classical Education:** "Classical Education" encompasses a range of traditions and interpretations (e.g., Dorothy Sayers' trivium model, Classical Christian Education, Great Books programs, etc.). The Humanitas Institute Audit of the Six Elements of Classical Education uses a broad, consensus-based framework derived from prominent classical education organizations and thought leaders. Reasonable people may disagree on weighting or inclusion of specific criteria.
4. **No Official Endorsement or Certification:** Results do not constitute official endorsement, accreditation, or certification by any classical education organization. They are provided for informational and research purposes only.
5. **Potential for Error:** Websites may be incomplete, poorly worded, or temporarily inaccurate. Conversely, sophisticated marketing language may create false positives. Human review by parents, educators, or classical education experts is strongly recommended before drawing final conclusions about any school.
6. **Data Privacy and Ethics:** Only publicly available information was analyzed. No attempts were made to access password-protected areas or collect personal data.
7. **No Liability:** The authors, developers, and distributors of this audit assume no liability for decisions made on the basis of these results. Users are solely responsible for their own due diligence.

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